

Module 1: Understanding the Basics of Excel

1. Excel Layout

Excel Layout is the overall structure of the Excel window where users enter, manage, and analyze data.

Think of Excel as a digital notebook. The layout is everything you see when you open Excel—the sheets, rows, columns, ribbon, formula bar, and menus.

Example

When you open Excel, you see:

- Ribbon at top
- Worksheet in center
- Rows on left
- Columns on top
- Sheet tabs at bottom

Interview Point

Excel Layout helps users organize and access tools efficiently.

One-Line Revision

Excel Layout is the complete working environment of Excel.

2. Workbook vs Worksheet

A Workbook is an Excel file, while a Worksheet is a single sheet inside that file.

Workbook = Notebook

Worksheet = Individual page of that notebook

Example

Sales_Report.xlsx

Contains:

- Sheet1 (January)
- Sheet2 (February)

- Sheet3 (March)

Interview Point

One workbook can contain multiple worksheets.

One-Line Revision

Workbook contains worksheets.

3. Ribbon, Tabs, Groups and Menus

The Ribbon is the command area at the top of Excel containing Tabs, Groups, and Menus.

Think of Ribbon as a toolbox.

Tabs are categories.

Groups are tool collections inside categories.

Example

Home Tab contains:

- Clipboard Group
- Font Group

- Alignment Group
- Number Group

Interview Point

The Ribbon helps users quickly access Excel commands.

One-Line Revision

Ribbon → Tabs → Groups → Commands.

4. Customizing the Quick Access Toolbar

The Quick Access Toolbar is a customizable toolbar that provides fast access to frequently used commands.

Instead of searching for the same tool repeatedly, place it on your personal shortcut bar.

Example

You can add:

- Save

- Undo
- Redo
- Print

to the Quick Access Toolbar.

Interview Point

Improves productivity by reducing navigation time.

One-Line Revision

Quick Access Toolbar stores your favorite shortcuts.

5. Cells, Rows, Columns

A. Cell

A cell is the intersection of a row and a column.

A cell is a single box where data is entered.

Example

A1, B5, C10

Interview Point

Every cell has a unique address.

One-Line Revision

Cell = Row + Column intersection.

B. Row

A row is a horizontal line of cells.

Rows move left to right.

Example

Row 1, Row 2, Row 3

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Rows are horizontal.

C. Column

A column is a vertical line of cells.

Columns move top to bottom.

Example

Column A, Column B, Column C

One-Line Revision

Columns are vertical.

D. Naming & Selecting

Selecting means choosing cells, rows, columns, or ranges for editing.

Before working on data, Excel needs to know what part you want to work with.

Example

- Click A1 to select one cell.
- Click row number to select row.
- Click column letter to select column.

One-Line Revision

Selection tells Excel where to perform actions.

E. Formatting

Formatting changes the appearance of data without changing its value.

Formatting is like dressing up your data.

Example

- Bold
- Font color
- Borders
- Currency format

One-Line Revision

Formatting changes appearance, not data.

F. Auto-Adjusting

Auto-adjusting automatically resizes rows or columns to fit content.

Excel automatically makes space for long text.

Example

Double-click column boundary.

Excel adjusts width automatically.

One-Line Revision

Auto-adjusting fits content automatically.

G. Creating & Deleting

Rows, columns, and cells can be added or removed as needed.

Like adding or removing pages from a notebook.

Example

Right Click → Insert

Right Click → Delete

One-Line Revision

Excel allows dynamic addition and removal of data structures.

6. Saving, Undo & Redo

Saving

Saving stores changes permanently in a workbook.

Without saving, your work can be lost.

Shortcut

Ctrl + S

One-Line Revision

Save protects your work.

Undo

Undo reverses the last action.

Shortcut

Ctrl + Z

One-Line Revision

Undo goes one step back.

Redo

Redo restores an undone action.

Shortcut

Ctrl + Y

One-Line Revision

Redo goes one step forward.

7. Intelligent Navigation

Intelligent Navigation refers to moving quickly within large datasets using shortcuts and navigation tools.

Instead of scrolling for hours, Excel provides shortcuts to jump instantly.

Examples

- Ctrl + Arrow Key
- Ctrl + Home
- Ctrl + End

Interview Point

Very useful in large datasets.

One-Line Revision

Navigate smarter, not harder.

8. Selecting Ranges

A range is a collection of two or more cells.

Selecting multiple cells together forms a range.

Example

A1:A10

A1:C10

One-Line Revision

Range = Multiple selected cells.

9. Copying & Pasting Mastery

Copying duplicates data while pasting places it elsewhere.

Like photocopying notes and placing them on another page.

Shortcuts

Ctrl + C → Copy

Ctrl + V → Paste

Ctrl + X → Cut

Interview Point

Learn Paste Special for professional work.

One-Line Revision

Copy duplicates, Cut moves.

10. Basic Arithmetic Operations

Excel performs mathematical calculations using formulas.

Excel acts like a calculator inside a spreadsheet.

Examples

=10+5

=10-5

=10*5

=10/5

Interview Point

Every formula begins with "=".

One-Line Revision

Excel calculations start with "=".

11. Cell Referencing

A. Relative Reference

Changes automatically when copied.

Example

=A1+B1

Copying downward changes references.

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Relative references change.

B. Absolute Reference

Remains fixed when copied.

Example

=A\$1

One-Line Revision

Absolute references never change.

C. Mixed Reference

Locks either row or column only.

Examples

=A\$1

A\$1

One-Line Revision

Mixed references partially lock rows or columns.

12. Different Techniques of Fills

Fill techniques automatically populate data, formulas, or patterns.

Instead of typing repeatedly, Excel continues the pattern for you.

Examples

Fill Handle

Drag:

1

2

3

Excel creates:

4

5

6

Auto Fill

Monday → Tuesday → Wednesday

Formula Fill

Copies formulas automatically.

Interview Point

Fill Handle is one of the most frequently used Excel productivity tools.

One-Line Revision

Fills automate repetitive work.